

Unit 6 Part B — Writing a One-sided Argumentative Essay

1. Purpose & example questions

Purpose

- To express your opinion on a **controversial** issue, arguing either for or against it
- Target audience — **students** (on the school newsletter), the **general public** (on newspapers and technology magazines)

Example questions

- *Social media does more harm than good to teenagers.*
- *Should schools ban AI chatbots from the classroom?*
- *Is the internet making us less able to concentrate?*

2. Planning your essay

Title	Choose ONE of three patterns: (1) Issue + verdict — <u>Social Media: More Harm Than Good</u> (2) Question — <u>Is Social Media Doing More Harm Than Good?</u> (3) Call to action — <u>Why We Must Rethink Social Media</u>
Introduction	1. Hook — one striking line, figure, image or short question <i>The average Hong Kong teenager now spends close to six hours a day on social media.</i> 2. Narrow the focus — link the issue to the audience <i>Social media is now ubiquitous and it quietly reshapes the way young people see themselves and one another.</i> 3. Stance — ONE side, in one sentence <i>I firmly believe that ... / It is undeniable that ...</i>
Body paragraphs 1 & 2	1. Topic sentence — a signpost + the argument itself <i>First and foremost, social media is detrimental to teenagers' mental health.</i> 2. Explain — build a cause-and-effect chain (X → Y → Z) <i>Platforms are designed to reward comparison, so users are constantly shown polished photographs of other people's lives, and they are encouraged to measure their own against them.</i> 3. Example — Findings / Real-world case / Typical process / Hypothetical scene <i>Findings — "According to the US Surgeon General's 2023</i>

	<i>advisory, adolescents who spend more than three hours a day on social media face double the risk of depression and anxiety."</i> <i>Real-world case — France has restricted phones in its middle schools since 2018 and in 2024 trialled a "digital pause", requiring pupils to hand in their phones for the whole school day. (Another: in November 2024, Australia legislated a minimum age of sixteen for social media accounts.)</i> <i>Typical process — Consider what happens when the app is opened for a five-minute break: the feed fills with classmates' holidays and prizes, an ordinary evening is set beside them, and self-doubt follows.</i> <i>Hypothetical scene - Imagine a Form 5 student who opens the app 'just for five minutes' before bed: two hours later the essay is untouched and the alarm is set for six.</i> Never write these (a marker spots them instantly) • invented names ("my friend Jason", "a Form 5 student called Mary") • invented percentages ("87% of students") 4. Round off — echo your topic sentence <i>Day after day, this comparison erodes self-esteem and exacerbates the anxiety that many teenagers already carry.</i>
Body paragraph 3 (counter-argument & rebuttal)	1. Concede — state the other side briefly <i>Admittedly, ... / Some may argue that ...</i> 2. Rebut — a concrete reason why the objection fails <i>However, this argument overlooks the fact that ...</i> 3. Round off — re-affirm your stance <i>Put simply, the convenience is real but modest, while the harm compounds year after year.</i>
Conclusion	1. Restate the stance in NEW words — do not copy the introduction 2. Summarise your arguments in one line. 3. Final thought — a call to action.

3. Practice - Complete the following writing plan	
Question: <i>Should schools ban AI chatbots from the classroom?</i> Your stance: <i>Affirmative / Negative</i> Green = Affirmative — schools should ban chatbots from the classroom. Blue = Negative — schools should keep them, but teach students to use them honestly. <i>The three body paragraphs use ONE example type each: Body 1 findings → Body 2 real-world case → Body 3 typical process.</i>	
Title	Affirmative — Issue + verdict: AI Chatbots in the Classroom: More Harm Than Good Negative — Call to action: Teach Students to Use Chatbots, Not to Hide From Them
Introduction	Hook: within seconds, a chatbot can produce the paragraph a student was supposed to write. Stance: schools should ban AI chatbots from the classroom. Hook: the same chatbot can explain a difficult idea at midnight, when no teacher is available. Stance: schools should teach students to use it honestly rather than ban it.
Body paragraph 1	Chatbots are detrimental to students' thinking Findings — In June 2025, an MIT Media Lab study found that students who wrote essays with ChatGPT showed the lowest brain engagement of any group, and were less able to recall their own writing. Chatbots are an indispensable study partner for students who cannot afford a tutor Findings — In 2025, a Harvard study of 194 students found that those who worked with an AI tutor learned more than twice as much, in less time, than those in a conventional class.
Body paragraph 2	They erode the value of assessed work: if an essay can be generated in seconds, marks stop measuring learning and honest students lose out. Real-world case — In January 2023, New York City's education department blocked ChatGPT on school networks and devices, saying it "does not build critical-thinking and problem-solving skills". A ban jeopardises the skills students will need: employers now expect AI literacy, and prohibition teaches fear instead of judgement. Real-world case — In September 2025, Estonia gave every grade 10–11 student and teacher free access to ChatGPT Edu, after training the teachers first.

Body paragraph 3	Concede: chatbots give weaker students instant explanations. Rebut: an explanation obtained without thinking is rarely remembered. Typical process — Consider what happens when a student copies a finished answer at midnight: the homework takes minutes, the idea is never understood, and the same question defeats them in the exam. Concede: some students will use chatbots to cheat. Rebut: a ban only drives that use out of sight, where no teacher can guide it; rules and disclosure teach judgement. Typical process — Consider what happens when a student is stuck at eleven at night: no teacher is awake, no classmate replies, and a chatbot explains the same step a third time until it makes sense.
Conclusion	Restate: a classroom where answers can be generated on demand is no longer a place where learning is measured. - Final thought: keep chatbots out of the work that shows what students can do alone. Restate: the answer is not prohibition but instruction. - Final thought: teach students to use chatbots openly, cite them honestly and check every claim they make.

4. Sample writing
Question: You have read an article in a local technology magazine claiming that social media does more harm than good to teenagers. Write an essay for the magazine arguing for OR against this view. Support your view with reasons and examples. (about 400 words) BOLD = <i>persuasive language</i> <u>Underlined</u> = <i>linking words and signals</i>.

Social Media: More Harm Than Good	Title
The average Hong Kong teenager now spends close to six hours a day on social media. That time could have been spent sleeping, revising or simply talking to family. Social media is now ubiquitous, and <u>although</u> it promises connection, it quietly reshapes the way young people see themselves and one another. I firmly believe that social media does more harm than good to teenagers. <u>First and foremost</u>, social media is detrimental to teenagers' mental health. Platforms are designed to reward comparison, <u>so</u> users are constantly shown polished photographs of other people's holidays and achievements, and pushed to measure their own lives against them. The evidence is no longer in doubt: according to the US Surgeon General's 2023 advisory,	Introduction - Hook - Stance Body 1 - Argument - Topic sentence - Explanation - Findings - Round off

adolescents who spend more than three hours a day on social media face double the risk of depression and anxiety. Day after day, this comparison erodes self-esteem and exacerbates anxiety — harm that is easy to miss <u>because</u> it feels normal. <u>Moreover</u>, the damage reaches beyond feelings into academic performance. Every notification leaves attention fragmented, making deep reading almost impossible to sustain. Late-night scrolling also delays sleep, which <u>in turn</u> undermines concentration in class. Governments have reached the same conclusion: France has restricted phones in its middle schools since 2018 and in 2024 trialled a “digital pause”, requiring pupils to hand in their phones for the whole school day. When the loss is measured in attention and sleep, convenience is a poor defence. <u>Some may argue that social media keeps teenagers connected and gives them a voice they would otherwise lack. Admittedly, a group chat can help a class organise a project, and a niche interest may find community online. However, these benefits are superficial when set against the costs. Consider what happens when a group chat becomes a teenager’s main company: the messages arrive all evening, every exchange stays on the surface, and real friendship is never attempted. A following built on ‘likes’ is rarely mutual support; at best, it is a short-lived substitute for friendship. Put simply, the convenience is real but modest, while the harm compounds year after year.</u> <u>In conclusion</u>, social media is not without value, yet its effects on teenagers’ well-being, concentration and self-image plainly outweigh its benefits. Banning the technology would be counterproductive; the answer is a deliberate effort to curb the hours we spend online. If teenagers can learn to switch off, they will discover that the world beyond the screen deserves their attention. (408 words)	Body 2 - Argument • Topic sentence • Explanation • Real-world case • Round off Body 3 - Counter-argument • Concede • Rebut • Typical process • Round off Conclusion • Restate stance • Summarise arguments • Final thought
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5. Language features — five reminders
<i>Both examples in each pair say the SAME thing. BOLD = persuasive language. Underlined = linking words.</i>

Reminder	✗ Poor example	✓ Upgraded example (from the sample)
Formal vocabulary <i>no “super”, “stuff”, “a lot of things”</i>	Social media <u>makes teenagers feel more worried</u> .	Social media exacerbates the anxiety teenagers already carry.
Passive voice ... be + past participle	Teenagers <u>always see</u> the perfect lives of other people on social media.	Teenagers are constantly exposed to polished images of other people’s

		lives on social media.
Persuasive language (<i>BOLD</i>)	Social media is <u>bad</u> for students.	Social media is detrimental to teenagers' mental health. Fragmented attention makes deep reading almost impossible to sustain .
Linking words (<i>underlined</i>)	Social media is harmful. Students cannot concentrate.	Social media is harmful; <u>as a result</u> , students can no longer concentrate.
Avoid personal pronouns 'you'	You can see that phones are super bad for students' focus.	It is undeniable that over-reliance on smartphones undermines students' concentration.

6. Quick reference	
Introduce and take a stance	In recent years, ... has become ubiquitous. I firmly believe that ... It is undeniable that ...
Open the first argument	First and foremost, ... The most serious consequence of ... is ...
Add an argument	Moreover, ... Worse still, ... Equally worrying is ...
Give an example	For instance, ... According to + [source] + ([year]), ... Consider what happens when ...
Concede, then rebut	Admittedly, ... Some may argue that ... However, ... What this overlooks is ...
Conclude and end	In conclusion, ...